

This is a solid creative brief — five real deliverables for a 12-min stickman explainer. Let me pull actual data for each part before I write anything.

Good foundation — I have real competitor videos. Now let me fill in Parts 2-5 with fresh research: what's being overdone, what's actually new in the arms-control world as of Aug 2026, and the audience angle.

This brief has five moving parts, and I've pulled live data on all of them. Here's the full research package for the 12-min stickman explainer.

PART 1 — Reference Videos to Study

Type A — Competitor videos (your catalog-style format twins + named channels):

Video	Channel	Views	Why watch
The Deadliest Weapons From Every Time Period12x	Just a Rock in Space	5.26M	Your closest format comp — animated "every era" timeline. Note how it segments by era and keeps a running arms-race thread across 11 min.
The Weirdest Weapons From Every Era Explained47x	ExplainTory	183K	Exact "Every X Explained" catalog formula. Study the pacing and the transition beats between entries.
Every War Crime Explained3.3x	Trust Me Bro	2.77M	<i>Every War Crime Explained</i> (Mar 2026) — same catalog format, directly on-topic, and recent. See how it opens with ancient rules to earn the hook.
Insane Weapons Banned From Modern Warfare	The Infographics Show	2.44M	Named in your brief. Watch how they frame "too deadly for war" without tipping into gore.
The Rules of war ALL Soldiers MUST OBEY	Simple History	800K	Named in your brief. 30-min deep dive on the rules of war — the legal-framework backbone.
Deadliest Chemical Weapons Ever Used in History	Chat History	1.68M	Chemical-weapons deep dive. Useful as the "don't do it this way" comp (see Part 2).
Weapons So Dangerous They Were Banned>100x	Smart Mind Channel	49K (breakout ×229)	<i>Weapons So Dangerous They Were Banned</i> — small channel, huge breakout vs its average. Proves the "banned weapons" appetite is real even with weak packaging.

Type B — Non-competitor educational (authority to borrow credibility from):

Video	Channel	Views	Why watch
What are the Rules of War? The Laws of War ICRC	ICRC (official)	7.4M	The authoritative explainer on international humanitarian law. Steal its framing of <i>why</i> the laws exist — the distinction/proportionality logic is your legal spine.
War Crimes Explained: The Rules of War, Crimes Against Humanity & Genocide6.4x	ABC News In-depth	84K	Journalistic legal explainer breaking down the Rome Statute's three crime categories. Clean model for how to define terms precisely.

PART 2 — Overused Angles to AVOID

- 1. Chemical-weapons-first. Every "banned weapons" video opens with mustard gas / sarin / napalm. It's the default and it's boring — viewers have seen it 50 times. Don't make it your opener.
- 2. "Too brutal" shock framing with no legal precision. The low-view videos in my search ([Most Terrifying BANNED Weapons in World War History](#) at 6 views, [Every BANNED WEAPON In War Explained In 6 Minutes4.3x](#) at 1.6K) all do "weapons so terrifying" countdowns that never cite the actual treaty. That's the dead zone — all vibe, no substance.
- 3. Conflating domestic gun law with international law. Videos like [Every Banned Gun Explained14x](#) (TEC-9, bump stock) treat US federal bans as if they're world bans. It muddies the real story. Keep domestic vs international strictly separate — or use the conflation itself as a teaching beat.
- 4. Pretending bans work. The naive version says "these weapons were banned, done." Reality: several haven't been used because of the ban *and* several keep getting used anyway (chemical weapons 1925→2013 sarin). Skipping that gap makes you sound like an AI listicle.
- 5. "Killer robots" fearmongering without the treaty context. Everyone waves the Terminator flag; almost nobody explains that autonomous weapons have *no* ban yet and one is being negotiated *right now*. That's your edge (Part 5).

PART 3 — Fresh Angles Nobody Is Covering

These are the beats that make it feel human and non-AI:

- 1. The law outruns the weapon. CCW Protocol IV banned blinding lasers in 1995 — *before a single soldier was blinded by one*. The St. Petersburg Declaration (1868) banned a bullet that barely existed. History's most interesting bans are preemptive — humans deciding "we won't build that" in advance. This is the closest thing to a thesis your video has.
- 2. The medieval church banned the crossbow. The Second Lateran Council (1139) outlawed crossbows and siege bows against Christians as "hateful to God" — because a peasant with a crossbow could kill a knight. It's a class panic dressed as morality, and it's a perfect stickman-comedy beat.
- 3. Bans channel cruelty instead of stopping it. Expanding bullets were banned in 1899 partly because they're designed to *wound*, not kill quickly — "superfluous injury." So armies quietly shifted to fragmenting and high-velocity rounds. The ban didn't end suffering; it redirected it. Inversion of your title's promise.
- 4. The landmine treaty almost failed — and one person mattered. The 1997 Ottawa Treaty got 122 signatories in a year, an unheard-of pace, with Diana's public campaign as a catalyst. Cluster munitions took 11 more years (2008). Great story about how bans actually get made.
- 5. The "too humane to be a war crime" twist — as a way to interrogate what "terrifying" even means. Is a weapon that disables (blinding, dum-dum) crueler than one that kills (a rifle round)? That's the ethical knot that makes a viewer think.

Pick 1 and 3 as your structural spine; 2 and 4 as human-interest color.

PART 4 — Primary Sources to Cite (credibility anchors)

Source	What it bans / defines	Why it's your credibility
St. Petersburg Declaration (1868)	Explosive projectiles under 400g	The <i>first</i> modern weapon ban — perfect cold open.
Hague Declaration III (1899)	Expanding (dum-dum) bullets	The "wound not kill" story.
Geneva Protocol (1925)	Chemical & biological weapons	The framework that still holds — and gets violated.
Geneva Conventions (1949) + AP I (1977), art. 35	"Superfluous injury or unnecessary suffering"	The actual legal test for what's banned.

Source	What it bans / defines	Why it's your credibility
CCW (1980): Prot. I (non-detectable fragments), II (mines), IV (1995 blinding lasers)	Wooden/plastic shrapnel, landmines, lasers	Give you the German wooden "shoe mine" (invisible to X-ray) — a wild, under-covered example.
Ottawa Treaty (1997)	Anti-personnel landmines	The Diana story. Note US/Russia/China never signed.
Convention on Cluster Munitions (2008)	Cluster bombs	Same note — big powers opted out.
Bernal Díaz del Castillo, <i>The True History of the Conquest of New Spain</i>	Firsthand account of Spanish vs Aztec weapons	Your brief named it — use it for the pre-modern section (Spanish banned crossbows/arquebuses among themselves vs. the <i>macuahuitl</i>).
Second Lateran Council (1139)	Crossbows	The "hateful to God" medieval beat.
Rome Statute (1998), art. 8	War crimes definitions	Grounds "what's a war crime" in one statute.

Also verify against the ICRC treaty database for Protocol IV:

[CCW Protocol IV on Blinding Laser Weapons \(ICRC\)](#)

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PART 5 — What's Happening RIGHT NOW (Aug 2026)

This is your timeliest asset, and it hands you the perfect forward-looking ending:

A brand-new weapons ban is being negotiated as we speak. The UN's talks on *lethal autonomous weapons* wrapped with 70+ countries pushing for a legally binding treaty by the end of 2026 — and the CCW's Seventh Review Conference this year is the moment states could formally launch negotiations. The UN Secretary-General set exactly that 2026 target. This isn't a historical "look back" — it's a ban being *born*, and it's the modern echo of your blinding-lasers beat (a weapon banned before it ever killed).

[Sept 2025 GGE joint statement \(Stop Killer Robots\)](#)

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[Draft rules on killer robots ready to negotiate \(Article 36\)](#)

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[Blinding-lasers precedent for a robots ban \(HRW\)](#)

Enforcement is in the news without naming any conflict. The OPCW's expert teams have been actively verifying treaty compliance in the field — a May 2026 deployment reported finding chemical weapons, and the Executive Council reinstated a state party's rights under the Chemical Weapons Convention in July 2026. There's also a landmark OPCW report (Mar 2026) on AI and the Chemical Weapons Convention — AI poisoning chemistry is a genuinely fresh, conflict-free hook that also ties your two halves together.

[OPCW report on AI and the CWC](#)

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[OPCW Executive Council, July 2026](#)

So your close writes itself: *"Every weapon on this list was banned after it was used. The one being debated right now might be the first banned before it ever fires a shot."* — that's the hook your title promises and the ending nobody else has.

Want me to turn Parts 2–5 into a structured 12-minute beat map (timestamps, which weapon opens, which closes), or draft the actual hook script for the first 30 seconds? I can also score a working title against your catalog format.